
Religion

An Open-Source Summary

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Contents

1 Class - 6 2

1.1 Scott 2007 2

1.2 Scott 2018 3

1.3 Summary of Lecture 4

2 License 7

2.1 Modification 7

2.2 Take down 7

Class summaries are handwritten and some are notebooklm generated.

1 Class - 6

1.1 Scott 2007

Joan Wallach Scott's *The Politics of the Veil* examines the underlying anxieties that led to the 2004 French law banning "conspicuous" religious signs in public schools, a law primarily aimed at the Muslim headscarf. Scott argues that the veil was not simply a religious garment, but became a screen onto which the French republic projected its deep-seated fears about immigration, national identity, and changing gender roles.

Here is a summary of the core arguments and themes in Scott's work:

The Timeline of the Controversies

Scott traces the *affaires des foulards* (headscarf controversies) through three key eruptions that demonstrate a progressive hardening of the French government's stance:

- **1989:** Three Muslim girls were expelled from a middle school in Creil for refusing to remove their headscarves in the name of *laïcité* (French secularism). At this time, the Council of State ruled that wearing religious signs was not incompatible with secularism, provided they did not constitute acts of provocation or proselytism, leaving room for accommodation.
- **1994:** Education Minister François Bayrou attempted to ban all "ostentatious" signs of religious affiliation, leading to the expulsion of 69 girls, though this decree was frequently overturned by the courts.
- **2003–2004:** Following intense media attention—such as the expulsion of the Lévy sisters, who had converted to Islam—and a government commission headed by Bernard Stasi, the government ultimately passed a law in 2004 definitively banning the headscarf in public schools, ending any room for mediation.

Political Motivations: Co-opting the Far Right

Scott argues that the 2004 ban was not a reaction to an objective worsening of religious extremism in schools, but rather a response to domestic political pressures. **Successive mainstream governments utilized the headscarf issue to capture the anti-immigrant vote and counter the rising popularity of Jean-Marie Le Pen's far-right National Front party.** By focusing on a few girls wearing headscarves, politicians were able to substitute a symbolic gesture for the much harder task of addressing the actual social, economic, and racial discrimination faced by North African immigrants.

The Clash with French Republican Universalism

A major driving force behind the ban was the ideology of French republicanism, which relies on **abstract individualism**. This ideology dictates that to be equal citizens, individuals must strip away their ethnic, religious, and social differences in the public sphere to achieve "sameness". Consequently, French republicans viewed the headscarf as a dangerous symbol of *communitarisme* (communalism)—a refusal to assimilate into a singular, homogenous national culture.

Sexuality and the "Open" vs. "Covered" Gender Systems

In Chapter 5, Scott explores how the language of the ban—specifically the choice to outlaw "conspicuous" or "ostentatious" signs—revealed a hidden preoccupation with sexuality. Scott contrasts two idealized gender systems to explain the intense French reaction:

- **The French "Open" System:** In France, women's emancipation and equality are culturally equated with the visibility of the female body and sexual availability. The exposure of the body is positively valued as a hallmark of liberty.

- **The Islamic “Covered” System:** In contrast, the Islamic tradition recognizes sexuality as a disruptive force that poses risks to social and political order. Modesty and the covering of the body are used to manage these libidinal energies and prevent sexual temptation.

For French observers, the veil was not seen as a sign of modesty, but rather as something perverse and sexually abnormal. **French politicians and feminists interpreted the veil as an aggressive rejection of French gender norms and a denial of men’s “natural” prerogative to look at women’s bodies.** President Jacques Chirac even described the veil as a “kind of aggression”. Some extreme commentators compared the psychological impact of the veil to genital mutilation, arguing it completely alienated young girls from their femininity, which in the French system is conferred by male desire and visual stimulation.

The Psychology of Denial

Scott concludes that the obsessive focus on saving Muslim women from their “oppressive” culture served as a convenient distraction for France. By pointing to Islam as the ultimate source of sexism, **French feminists and politicians engaged in a “psychology of denial,” allowing them to ignore the ongoing gender inequalities, wage discrimination, and domestic violence within their own borders.** Ultimately, the headscarf ban was a way for France to assert the absolute superiority of its own civilization and naturalize its specific cultural approach to sex and equality.

1.2 Scott 2018

Based on the provided excerpts from Joan Wallach Scott’s 2018 book *Sex and Secularism*, the article challenges the popular contemporary assumption that secularism inherently guarantees gender equality. Scott argues that this association is a historically false, politically motivated invention used primarily to assert Western superiority over Islam, while distracting from ongoing gender disparities within Western societies.

Here is a summary of the core arguments:

The False History of Secularism and Gender Equality

Scott approaches secularism genealogically, viewing it not as a fixed definition but as a discourse that changes depending on its political context. She points out that when the concept of secularism emerged in the 18th and 19th centuries, the separation of church and state actually relied on **gender inequality**. Western modernity assigned women to a feminized, private sphere of family and religion, while reserving the rational, public realms of politics and economics for men. Gender equality was completely absent from the founding documents of Western democracies. It was only in the late 20th century, amidst the “clash of civilizations” rhetoric, that gender equality was retroactively claimed as a primordial value of secularism.

Christian Secularism and the “Muslim Question”

The modern discourse of secularism has deep roots in colonial history and is heavily intertwined with Christian exceptionalism. By contrasting an allegedly enlightened, sexually liberated West against a supposedly repressed, misogynistic Islamic “other,” secularism functions to justify claims of white, Western, and Christian racial superiority. Scott compares the modern stigmatization of Muslims in Europe to the 19th-century “Jewish Question,” arguing that a racialized view of Islamic culture is now used to portray Muslims as fundamentally incompatible with European democratic life.

Sexual Emancipation vs. True Equality

In the chapter titled “Sexual Emancipation,” Scott critiques the contemporary Western tendency to conflate gender equality with sexual freedom. She observes that in modern secular discourse, human agency is heavily reduced to the

fulfillment of sexual desire. Consequently, emancipation is often narrowly equated with the public exposure of the female body and the freedom to act as a consumer.

- **The “Covered” vs. “Uncovered” Binary:** Western discourse relies on a strict opposition between “covered” Muslim women, who are deemed sexually repressed and trapped in the past, and “uncovered” Western women, who are considered autonomous and liberated.
- **The Illusion of Freedom:** Scott notes that the Western “liberated” ideal often simply translates to the freedom to conform to conventional, market-driven norms of femininity that cater to male desire. She argues that pushing Muslim women to “unveil” is closely linked to capitalist demands that women participate in the market as both consumers and commodities.
- **A Distraction from Structural Inequality:** Scott stresses that historically, emancipation (the lifting of formal legal restraints) is not the same thing as substantive equality. By focusing obsessively on sexual desire and the visibility of women’s bodies as the ultimate metric of freedom, Western nations create a convenient distraction from deeply rooted structural inequalities—such as wage disparities, glass ceilings, domestic violence, and lack of social support—that continue to affect women globally.

Ultimately, Scott concludes that secularism operates as a polemical discourse that uses the language of gender equality to define national borders, perpetuate racial hierarchies, and mask the unresolved challenges of gender inequality within the West itself.

1.3 Summary of Lecture

France in the 90’s, the “laïcité” debate

1989:

- **Ernest Chénier** → Principal in a school who expelled 3 hijabi.
- Council of State (highest instance): wearing religious is okay as long it is not an “act of pressure, provocation, proselytism, or propaganda” → NOT incompatible with laïcité BUT school must decide case by case

1994:

- **Bayrou** → Minister of Education at the time
- BANS all signs of religious affiliation → they are intrinsically part of proselytize
- 69 girls expelled
- Council of state overturns it → Back to 89

2003:

- **Alma & Lila Lévy** → 2 french girls converted to Islam
- **Chirac** → French President → Ask Stasi for a commission to examine the religious signs ban
 - **March 2024:** Ban all religious signs besides small one (no more kippa, hijab, or cross)

2009:

- Nicolas Sarkozy → French President instates a commission for Muslims for their cult
- stated the burqa would not be tolerated, framing it not as a religious issue, but as an affront to women’s freedom, dignity, and a modern form of “enslavement”

Now:

- Debate motivated by the rise of populism far right (Rassemblement national/Lepen) takes that debate
- Debate is much deeper:

- Security issue
- Freedom and men's control over woman → autonomous self
- Islam and France's culture and traditions

Scott:

- Racism:
 - Rooted in the north african colonialism of france and systematic marginalization of muslim immigrants
- Secularism + Individualism:
 - "Liberté,Égalité,Fraternité" → "Freedom, Equality, Brotherhood"
 - Rooted in French identity to be free
- Larger social issues + Sexuality
 - French → openness; Islam → modesty

Behind the debate:

- Clash between sex and sexuality → France and Islam have 2 views:
 - France: Open: Woman must and can be sexualized
 - * Putting a veil is seen as a restriction on woman and man's own desire and sexuality
 - * Sexual promiscuity and freedom is seen as liberty
 - * **Psychology of denial:** We assume that even though there a sexual difference, **they can be ignored** and do not matter in a free society
 - Islam: Covered: modest and sexual *unavailable*
 - * **Psychology of recognition:** There are **differences between male and female** AND THUS we should avoid that sexuality disrupts the public space and keep it in **private sphere** rather than public

Sex and Secularism:

- Secularism = freedom + gender equality ?
 1. Gender equality **NEVER** been at the center of secularism discourse
 2. Using gender equality as an argument for secularism → Aims to prove western superiority (not factual)
 3. We are not looking at the right issue and it's just a shortcut avoiding the real difficulties
- 19th and 20th Centuries:
 1. Promiscuity vs procreation
 2. Private sphere = Feminine WHILE Public = politic = manley
 3. Women in kitchen → not just religious thing but product of discourse of secularism
 4. Wait years for woman to start have the same right (100 years after french and American revolutions) → secularism has never been about woman freedom
 5. When Islam came to western world → THEN woman rights were taken as a part of "**New**" **Secularism → Sexual liberation**
 - Women are **instrumentalized** → giving rights was not just of pure kindness but because it comforted western society in their supposed superiority over islam
 - **Sexual emancipation != gender equality**
 - It is like **liberal feminism** → Men pose as the savior but actually we just change the exploiter
 - * From being exploited by aytollah for the headscarf → exploited by pimp on onlyfans cause "that's freedom"
 - * Never a true emancipation → woman is still an object, just flashy rebranding, stays a commodity
 - Foucault: actual emancipation is de-sexualization
 - Sexuality + politics → always an unstable discourse

- How to achieve emancipation ?
 1. Definitions:
 - “Lifting of restraints imposed by superior physical force or legal obligation” (Oxford English Dictionary)
 - Patria potestas (roman law)
 - NOT ABOUT EQUALITY → about freedom
 2. Reification of desire
 - Sexuality is singled out
 - Motivate actions by desire
 - Freedom act upon and fulfill desires (no equality in gender)

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